

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 1067

By Haile

A RESOLUTION to honor and celebrate the 175th anniversary of the YMCA.

WHEREAS, the Young Men's Christian Association (YMCA or "the Y") marks its 175th anniversary this year, having been founded in the United States by Thomas Valentine Sullivan at the Old South Church in Boston on December 29, 1851; inspired by the YMCA movement in England, the organization pursued a mission to put Christian principles into practice by building healthy spirit, mind, and body for all; and

WHEREAS, the YMCA has continually adapted to meet the evolving needs of American communities, strengthening society by bringing people together, fostering relationships, and creating a sense of belonging; and

WHEREAS, the YMCA's legacy is inextricably tied to the history and progress of our nation; the YMCA provided safe housing during the Industrial Revolution; pioneered the first night school and English as a second language classes; and delivered the first group swim lessons; and

WHEREAS, the YMCA is widely known as the birthplace of basketball, but it is also the birthplace of Father's Day, with the first celebration having been held at the Spokane YMCA in 1910; and

WHEREAS, the YMCA established the Youth and Government program in 1936, a premier civic engagement initiative that continues today; and

WHEREAS, the YMCA has led humanitarian efforts during wartime, including the work of YMCA leader and President Wilson's General Secretary for the National War Work Council, John R. Mott, who received the Nobel Peace Prize in 1946 for the undertaking; and

WHEREAS, the YMCA has been the nation's leading nonprofit provider of childcare and afterschool programs since the 1970s and 1980s to support working families; and

WHEREAS, the YMCA is the leading provider of emergency childcare for front-line workers and was a significant provider of food during the COVID pandemic; and

WHEREAS, today, 2,600 YMCAs serve more than 10,000 communities nationally in every state and territory, with more than 300,000 staff and 350,000 volunteers delivering essential programs to more than seventeen million people annually, including nearly eleven million adults and 6.5 million children and youth; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee YMCAs currently serve over seventy percent of Tennessee counties and impact nearly 300,000 youth across the State; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee YMCAs are the state's largest nonprofit provider of childcare and afterschool programs, caring for more than 192,000 children; and

WHEREAS, Tennessee YMCAs provide more than 21,000 swim lessons to children, distribute nearly six million meals, and serve as the largest provider of fitness programs for older adults—reaching more than 116,000 seniors across the State; and

WHEREAS, "the Y" serves people of all ages, backgrounds, and abilities, creating spaces where all people feel welcome, are treated with respect, and find opportunities to connect with their neighbors; and

WHEREAS, YMCAs across the nation are working to build stronger, more connected communities through intentional experiences that help people achieve their goals, foster connection, and promote well-being in order to build relationships and thrive; and

WHEREAS, in 2026, YMCAs nationwide will host special events that celebrate the moments, programs, and people that have shaped their story; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH
GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF

REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we congratulate and express appreciation to the YMCA for 175 years of service to the nation and honor the YMCA's role in responding to community needs, connecting people, fostering support, building relationships, and creating a sense of belonging.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we commend the hundreds of thousands of staff and volunteers who create connected communities and advance the YMCA's mission to build healthy spirits, minds, and bodies for all.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we honor the YMCA's efforts to address social isolation and loneliness by creating places and spaces that promote achievement, well-being, and connection and help people build relationships and thrive.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.